GUEST COLUMN: MITHALI RAJ

Our Midnight Tryst With Destiny

In monetary gain, perception shift and the realisation of a long-held dream, the 2025 World Cup marks a watershed for women's cricket in India



Mithali Raj is a former captain of the Indian women's cricket team

When Harmanpreet leapt forward to grab that World Cup-winning catch and the roar of DY Patil Stadium in Navi Mumbai shook the night sky, I felt something shift deep within. It wasn't just a victory. It was a dream fulfilled—one that generations of Indian women cricketers carried in our hearts. For years, we spoke of 1983—that golden summer when Indian cricket changed forever. All us women used to wonder, 'When will women's cricket in India have its 1983 moment?' Last Sunday night, we finally did. India lifted its first-ever ICC Women's Cricket World Cup trophy, defeating South Africa.

This triumph was not born overnight. It was in the making for a couple of decades—a story of resilience, belief and collective will. I saw those same emotions mirrored in the faces of Harmanpreet, Smriti, Shafali, Jemimah, Richa, Deepti—young hearts who carried the hopes of a nation with grace and grit.

Women's cricket in India began as a story of borrowed kits and empty stands. Many of us played when recognition was a luxury. But things started to change in the last few years—not just in the game, but around it too.

Much of this transformation owes to the intent and vision of a few. In his capacity as BCCI secretary and now as ICC chairman, Jay Shah has ushered in reforms that offer real change—introducing pay parity for women, launching the Women's Premier League, investing more in grassroots talent development, increasing prize money and match fees across domestic tournaments.

Just as 1983 inspired my generation to dream, 2025 will inspire the next. A girl from anywhere in India playing cricket knows that, with hard work, success is within her grasp

When the ICC Women's Cricket World Cup returned to India after 12 years, expectations were high. Record prize money of $13.88 million (Rs 123.1 crore)—a steeper increase than in any of the previous editions—made a statement: women's cricket was no longer an afterthought, but a mainstage spectacle.

Accessible ticket prices starting at Rs 100 opened stadium gates to families and first-time fans. Broadcasts in five Indian languages—and for the first time an Indian Sign Language feed—turned it into a celebration of inclusion. Thus, the 2025 World Cup marks a watershed for women's cricket. The records made in stadium attendance and by a viewership of millions across platforms speak of a perception shift among fans. Key region-specific activities and a trophy tour that touched millions across venues proved that women's cricket is not 'emerging' anymore—it has arrived.

Just as 1983 inspired my generation to dream, 2025 will inspire the next. When a girl from any corner of India will choose cricket, she won't have to wonder if it's practical to dream big. She now knows that, with hard work and dedication, success will always be within her grasp.

Because we didn't just win a World Cup—we changed what victory looks like once and for all by shattering the proverbial glass ceiling. Need I say this is only the beginning! *Aage aage dekho picture abhi bahut baaki hai....*



MOMENT TO REMEMBER Fans celebrating the victory at India Gate in New Delhi, Nov. 3

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